**Jerrabomberra Residents Association Inc.**

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**SUBMISSION: Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters – Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election**

The Jerrabomberra Residents Association (JRA) welcomes the opportunity to provide a submission to the Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election.

Formed in 1990, the JRA is a member-based organisation representing the interests of the Jerrabomberra community at the local, state and federal level in relation to issues directly affecting the Jerrabomberra community, within the postcode of 2619.

The semi-rural suburb of Jerrabomberra sits within the federal electorate of Eden-Monaro in New South Wales (NSW). It is located next to the eastern side of the ACT-NSW border, around six kilometres from the NSW town of Queanbeyan. The Queanbeyan-Palerang Council's 2025 population forecast for Jerrabomberra is 9,335[1]. In the lead up to the 2025 federal election, 6365 people voted at the Jerrabomberra Pre-Poll Voting Centre[2]. On polling day, 3 May 2025, 2188 people voted at the Jerrabomberra polling place[3].

The JRA wishes to comment on the first three terms of reference for the inquiry, as set out below. In the 35-year history of the JRA, this is the first election where significant issues were observed at polling places and in the local community more generally.

The JRA's submission is based on feedback and observations about the conduct of political parties, their volunteers and voters in relation to the conduct of the 2025 federal election in Jerrabomberra. These were provided by JRA members and members of the Jerrabomberra community who made comments either directly to the JRA or in local public forums, including at the Jerrabomberra 'Meet the Candidates' forum on 29 April 2025 and on the JRA Facebook page and the Jerrabomberra Community Noticeboard site on Facebook.

At the outset, the JRA notes the extraordinary circumstances relating to the conduct of the 2025 election in Jerrabomberra due to the influx of large numbers of Plymouth Brethren Christian Church (Brethren) members volunteering for the [redacted] Party candidate. Their volunteering activities included handing out how-to-vote cards at polling booths and shopping centres, doorknocking residents' houses, driving large trucks featuring [redacted] Party

[1] https://forecast.id.com.au/queanbeyan-palerang/about-forecast-areas?WebID=160
[2] Jerrabomberra PPVC – polling place, AEC Tally Room, 27 May 2025: https://results.aec.gov.au/31496/Website/HousePollingPlaceFirstPrefs-31496-108984.htm
[3] Jerrabomberra – polling place, AEC Tally Room, 27 May 2025: https://results.aec.gov.au/31496/Website/HousePollingPlaceFirstPrefs-31496-31436.htm

signage around polling booths and waving the [redacted] Party candidate's corflutes on the side of busy main roads. At the pre-poll booth, a Brethren Liberal Party volunteer informed the JRA President that they were generally not from the local area and had travelled long distances to volunteer in Jerrabomberra. The JRA questions the appropriateness of the Brethren volunteers' activities in Jerrabomberra, noting that, by choice, they do not vote or participate in the democratic process and had no knowledge of or interest in local issues.

The JRA posits that the overwhelming presence, and in some instances, negative behaviour of some of those volunteers at Jerrabomberra polling booths and shopping centres respectively had a profound impact on voters' perception of their voting experience and on other polling booth volunteers' experience at the election. This has significant implications for the conduct of future elections, and for the community's faith in the democratic process and democracy more broadly.

By providing a submission to this inquiry, the JRA wishes to see change in the way that future federal elections are conducted in Jerrabomberra to ensure that the behaviour observed at and conduct of the 2025 federal election is not repeated. The JRA's ideas for reform are set out in the recommendations.

1. **Assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials.**

**Anti-social and aggressive behaviour**
The following incidents and behaviour were observed by and reported to the JRA as occurring outside the Jerrabomberra Pre-Poll Voting Booth and Polling Day Booth, involving [redacted] Party volunteers:

- Verbal aggression directed at volunteers from other political parties.
- Physically obstructing volunteers from other political parties as they tried to hand out how-to-vote cards to voters.
- Refusing to move or reluctantly moving out of the way when requested by volunteers from other political parties who were trying to retrieve their personal belongings from behind the volunteer line.
- Intimidating a female volunteer from another political party by aggressively staring at her as she handed out how-to-vote cards outside the Polling Day Booth and causing her to feel uncomfortable.
- Accosting voters and forcefully encouraging them to vote for the [redacted] Party candidate, including using the phrase 'Make Australia smile again!'. One clearly irritated female voter who was accosted in this way was overheard to exclaim, 'Leave me alone – you can't tell me how to vote!'
- It should be noted that this behaviour only improved after a complaint was made by another political party to the local AEC election coordinator.

The following incidents were reported involving voters:

- One volunteer who was handing out how-to-vote cards for the [redacted] candidate at the Pre-Poll Voting Booth reported that she and another [redacted] volunteer and her three-year-old granddaughter were physically intimidated and verbally abused by a male voter on his way into and out of the polling booth. Unprovoked, the perpetrator targeted the two

female volunteers, ranted and screamed foul abuse at them while accusing them of being 'kiddy snippers' and filmed them on his mobile phone while taunting them. Neither volunteer responded. One of the female volunteers had to turn her back and walk away from the perpetrator to escape the abuse. This incident left both volunteers feeling unsafe, shaken and angry. Neither volunteer had given their permission to be filmed. Many of the male [redacted] Party volunteers laughed, clapped and cheered the perpetrator, appearing to encourage and sanction this gender-based violence as he entered and exited the polling booth, and neither intervened nor gave support to the two volunteers who were subjected to the violence. While the volunteer reported this incident to the Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) and Queanbeyan Police, she noted with considerable dismay that there was no protocol or guidelines communicated to volunteers in terms of how to handle or report such incidents, either from the AEC or the political party she was volunteering for. It appeared to her that both organisations were woefully underprepared to deal with the increasing incidents of violence occurring at polling booths.

- The 'temperature' at polling booths was reported to be significantly higher at polling booths at this federal election than at previous elections, based on some voters' antagonistic comments to volunteers that were political in nature, provocative and unnecessary.

**An overwhelming, intimidating presence at polling booths, shopping centres and during doorknocking visits**

The following incidents and behaviour were observed by and reported to the JRA as occurring outside Jerrabomberra polling booths, shopping centres and during doorknocking visits, involving [redacted] Party volunteers:

- Based on observations and feedback from Jerrabomberra residents, it is clear to the JRA that the presence of excessive numbers of volunteers at both the Jerrabomberra Pre-Poll Voting Booth and Polling Day Booth were perceived as overwhelming and intimidating by many voters.
- On Saturdays at the Pre-Poll Voting Booth, volunteers lined both sides of the stairs leading up to the Jerrabomberra Community Centre and there was also a long line of volunteers stretching along the front of the centre. The JRA understands that the large number of [redacted] Party volunteers caused other political parties such as the [redacted] to try to 'match' their numbers so that the total number of volunteers at the booth ended up being excessive. Many voters clearly felt overwhelmed, intimidated or irritated at the oversupply of volunteers and felt they had to 'run the gauntlet' to enter the polling booth. This was evidenced by negative comments overheard such as 'This is too much!', 'You've got be joking!' and other less polite comments.
- Likewise, on polling day, at one stage there were around 16 [redacted] Party volunteers at the front entrance to the Jerrabomberra Public School Polling Day Booth, four [redacted], one [redacted] Party and one [redacted] Party volunteer. Some voters expressed annoyance that the path into the Jerrabomberra Public School polling booth was unclear and blocked by volunteers and corflutes. Comments on the local Facebook page indicated that some voters, including the elderly, people with disabilities and those suffering from anxiety conditions, felt so intimidated by the overwhelming presence of volunteers at both pre-poll and polling day booths that they had to either summon up the courage to approach the booth or were completely put off and turned around and went home without voting.

- [redacted] Party volunteers were a constant presence at the local Jerrabomberra Shopping Village on a daily basis in the six weeks leading up to the election, and at Aldi six days prior. This manifested itself in terms of groups of volunteers calling out to shoppers and handing them how-to-vote cards, positioning A-frames close to shopping centre entrances and parking cars with [redacted] Party signage close to the entrance. Once again, some shoppers expressed their frustration at having to 'run the gauntlet' to enter the shopping centre and felt harassed and annoyed at having to continually refuse how-to-vote cards or other election material that they had previously been offered.
- Some local residents, particularly elderly residents or those living alone, conveyed to the JRA their discomfort at having a group of two or three large male [redacted] Party volunteers on their doorstep promoting their candidate. For example, on Easter Sunday, three large male [redacted] Party volunteers knocked on the door of an elderly resident who lives alone. This was frightening for the resident who also complained that this activity was being undertaken on a Christian holiday that was sacred to them.

**Distracting behaviour and excessive numbers of corflutes displayed on local roads**

- Some Jerrabomberra residents complained about the regular presence of [redacted] Party volunteers jumping up and down and waving corflutes on the side of main roads in Jerrabomberra, such as Lanyon and Tompsitt Drives. The complaint was that the volunteers' actions were distracting and could potentially cause a road accident.
- Hundreds of the [redacted] Party candidate's corflutes were placed along main roads in Jerrabomberra, without authorisation.

**Candidates' behaviour at the Meet the Candidates night**

- The JRA has hosted many 'Meet the Candidates' forums over the last 20 years which give local residents the opportunity to hear the views and policies of Eden-Monaro candidates and ask questions prior to the election. These are well-run and attended events that generally go smoothly. Unfortunately, this year's event was marred by several candidates spruiking extreme conspiracy theories that bore little relation to the federal election issues raised and questions being put to them. The JRA noted this as a significant change in the behaviour of candidates compared to previous years.

**<u>Recommendations</u>**

- Volunteers for political parties at polling booths should be at least 18 years of age <u>and</u> registered voters.
- The AEC should set and enforce limits on the number of volunteers from each political party who can hand out how-to-vote cards outside polling booths at any one time.
- The AEC should undertake a risk assessment for the delivery of polling services, specifically focusing on the increasing incidents of violence and intimidation and devise a strategy, in cooperation with political parties, for the prevention, handling and reporting of such incidents on-site.
- Political parties should be required to educate volunteers on the agreed strategy for the prevention, handling and reporting of incidents that occur outside polling booths.
- Volunteers should be required to sign a code of conduct prior to undertaking volunteer activities at polling booths. Political parties are to be held responsible for the conduct of their volunteers.

**2. Potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour.**

Based on the information provided above under the first term of reference, the JRA contends that increased security arrangements are required at polling booths for future elections to keep AEC staff, volunteers and voters safe.

**Recommendations**

- The AEC should undertake a risk assessment of the safety and security of AEC staff, volunteers and voters at polling booths and formulate and implement safety plans and arrangements accordingly.
- At a minimum, the AEC should be required to provide security guards outside each polling booth for the safety and wellbeing of volunteers and voters.
- The AEC should highlight accepted standards of behaviour and the consequences of anti-social and aggressive behaviour for voters and volunteers in the lead up to elections, in advertising, election mail-outs, social media posts and on the AEC website.
- The AEC should hold political parties responsible for the conduct of their volunteers and have the power to remove volunteers who are displaying threatening or disruptive behaviour at polling places.

**3. The suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements.**

The JRA believes that while pre-poll voting provides voters with convenience, it diminishes the significance of Polling Day. Polling Day is held at the end of a six-week election campaign and provides the opportunity for voters to vote with awareness of a full suite of election policies. It is also an important way of educating young people about democracy and gives schools the opportunity to raise valuable funds by holding community events such as 'democracy sausage' barbecues and cake stalls. Polling Day is integral to democracy through its role of educating the next generation of voters and future election candidates. It is therefore important that Polling Day is experienced positively by all and retains its core function as the main day for casting votes.

In addition, the current lengthy pre-poll voting period of up to two weeks does not provide equal opportunity for all candidates. A pre-poll period of more than one week favours the two main political parties, who have the resources and funding to staff Pre-Poll Booths for an extended period of time. It is difficult for small parties or independent candidates to match these resources on a daily basis and to be seen and heard at pre-poll. The representation of a variety of voices and political views in an election campaign is central to a healthy democracy and it also for this reason that the JRA believes that the pre-poll period should be shortened to one week.

The JRA would also like to see election dates selected to avoid campaigning during significant public holidays such as Easter and Anzac Day which have religious and personal

significance for many people. In this way, the intrusion of political campaigning on people's lives can be minimised.

**Recommendations**

- The AEC should shorten the pre-poll period to one week to encourage people to vote on Polling Day.
- The AEC should undertake a public advertising campaign promoting the significance and benefits of voting on Polling Day.
- Election dates should be selected to avoid political campaigning during religious and personally significant public holidays such as Easter and Anzac Day.

Thank you for considering our submission.

Yours sincerely

[redacted]

Margot Sachse
President
Jerrabomberra Residents Association

26 September 2025